



The Principles You Already Signed

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 To the architects and city planners now under pressure to build, and build fast: this is not written to slow you down. The shortage is real. The United States is short roughly 3.5 to 4 million homes as of 2024, a gap the National Association of Home Builders and the Urban Institute have tracked across boom and bust alike, and in most metro areas median rent has climbed at twice the pace of median wages over the past decade, so that more than 50 million households, about one in three, now spend past the federal benchmark of 30 percent of income just to stay housed. No one who has read those figures wants you idle. The pressure to add units is not a distortion of your duty. It is your duty.

2 But it is not the whole of it, and you said so first. When you adopted the Charter of the New Urbanism in 1996, you committed your profession to walkability, to mixed-use neighborhoods, to streets built at human scale; when the American Institute of Architects bound its members to safeguard the health, safety, and welfare of the public and to work toward an improved quality of life; when you taught a generation to design for the eight-year-old and the eighty-year-old on the theory that a street good for both is good for everyone, you set down a standard that a tally of finished units cannot, by itself, satisfy. [Anaphora] The Project for Public Spaces calls the same thing placemaking. You have many names for it.

3 I grant that you did not write the zoning codes that restrict apartments across most of the country, nor the financing rules that reward unit count over the public realm, nor the cost pressures that turn a ground floor meant for a shop into one more wall. [Concession] These are real, and they are not chiefly yours. Still, the research your own bodies publish is hard to set aside. The Urban Land Institute and the American Planning Association find that moderate density, somewhere around 15 to 25 homes an acre in walkable settings, can lower per-unit cost and hold livability at once; the same literature finds that residents of such places drive less and walk more, which trims their transportation bills and, the public-health work suggests, their isolation. Density and human scale are not opposed. The work says you can have both.

4 Amsterdam manages it. Barcelona manages it. Greenwich Village, blocks of it, has managed it for a century. [Allusion] What those places share is not a magic number of stories but a street that does something at eye level: a plaza, a doorway, a shop you can walk into. Duany and Plater-Zyberk argued a quarter century ago that sprawl was not an accident but the result of abandoning exactly that, and the profession largely agreed. The harder admission, which your own journals have started to make, is that density can fail the same test from the other direction. A tower with a blank base adds homes and subtracts a neighborhood. Occupied is not the same as alive.

5 So I will not ask you to choose livability over housing, because that is the false choice your own scholarship rejects, and I will not ask you to ignore a crisis that costs one in three households more than they can spare. [Antithesis] I ask something narrower and, I think, fairer. When the next pro forma comes back and the ground floor is the line item easiest to cut, hold it to the charter you signed. Build the homes.

Build them so a child and an old woman would both want to be on the street outside. That part was always the assignment. You wrote it down.

Devices, and why they are here:

Anaphora (paragraph 2): “When you adopted the Charter of the New Urbanism in 1996, you committed your profession to walkability, to mixed-use neighborhoods, to streets built at human scale; when the American Institute of Architects bound its members to safeguard the health, safety, and welfare of the public and to work toward an improved quality of life; when you taught a generation to design for the eight-year-old and the eighty-year-old on the theory that a street good for both is good for everyone, you set down a standard that a tally of finished units cannot, by itself, satisfy.” The repeated “When you... when the... when you taught” frame stacks the addressee’s own past commitments under one rising structure, so the moral weight is built by accumulation of their professed values rather than by the writer’s assertion; it also performs the deference the register requires, deferring the main clause to the end of a long periodic sentence.

Concession (paragraph 3): “I grant that you did not write the zoning codes that restrict apartments across most of the country, nor the financing rules that reward unit count over the public realm, nor the cost pressures that turn a ground floor meant for a shop into one more wall.” Granting that zoning, financing, and cost pressures are not the architects’ fault gives the opposing reality its genuine force before the letter turns; the concession costs the writer the easy blame and makes the subsequent appeal to the profession’s own research land as fair rather than accusatory, the central disarming move of the Open Letter.

Allusion (paragraph 4): “Amsterdam manages it. Barcelona manages it. Greenwich Village, blocks of it, has managed it for a century.”

Naming Amsterdam, Barcelona, and Greenwich Village borrows the reader’s existing image of those famously livable places as proof that dense and humane coexist; the reference does the work an argument would, and these are recognizable enough that the borrowed meaning lands immediately.

Antithesis (paragraph 5): “So I will not ask you to choose livability over housing, because that is the false choice your own scholarship rejects, and I will not ask you to ignore a crisis that costs one in three households more than they can spare.”

Setting livability-over-housing against ignoring-the-crisis in balanced parallel form lets the writer refuse both false poles at once and clear the ground for the narrower request; the balanced contrast names the dilemma precisely so the charge that follows feels reasoned, not evasive.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer concedes that architects did not author the zoning codes, financing rules, or cost pressures primarily in order to

- A) grant the opposing reality its real force so that the appeal to the profession’s own research reads as fair rather than accusatory
- B) establish that the profession bears no responsibility for the housing crisis and should be left alone
- C) shift the argument toward reforming municipal zoning law as the only workable solution
- D) demonstrate that the writer possesses technical command of development finance

2. The short sentence "Occupied is not the same as alive" at the end of the fourth paragraph primarily serves to

- A) accuse developers of deliberately building uninhabitable housing
- B) soften the preceding criticism of towers by conceding their practical usefulness
- C) compress the paragraph's point about density without street-level life into a flat, memorable contrast
- D) introduce a new statistic about vacancy rates in high-density buildings

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer A. The concession grants ground precisely so the turn to the profession's own published research lands as fair; the piece concedes then advances. The claim that the profession bears no responsibility inverts the writer's stance, since the letter still presses architects to honor their charter. Reforming zoning law as the sole solution imports a purpose the paragraph never makes its primary aim; zoning is named as context, not the proposed fix. Crediting the writer with finance expertise is true-but-not-the-function, mistaking a minor texture of the passage for the concession's job.

2. Answer C. The clipped line lands the paragraph's argument that added units without an active street fail the profession's own livability test, set hard against the longer sentences before it. Reading it as softening the criticism inverts its effect, since it sharpens rather than relieves the point. Claiming it introduces a vacancy statistic imports data the passage never states. Reading it as accusing developers of deliberate uninhabitability is over-broad, pushing a measured contrast into an extreme charge the text does not make.

Discussion questions:

1. The letter spends its entire first paragraph granting the urgency of the housing crisis before it raises a single objection. How does conceding so much ground early change the way you receive the request in the final paragraph? Would the appeal be more or less persuasive if it opened with the criticism instead?
2. The writer repeatedly holds architects to standards architects themselves established (the 1996 Charter, the AIA code of ethics, the 8-80 principle) rather than to standards the writer invents. Why might borrowed authority be more effective here than the writer asserting their own view of what good design requires?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. Granting the crisis first disarms the reader who might otherwise expect a scold. By the time the writer reaches the request, we have already agreed that the shortage is real and that building is a genuine duty, so the final ask cannot be dismissed as someone who does not understand the stakes. The concession buys standing. Opening with criticism would have framed the writer as an opponent of housing, and architects under deadline pressure would have read the rest defensively. Because the letter has visibly taken their side on the hard fact first, the narrower request, to protect the ground floor and the street, reads as a refinement of a shared goal rather than an attack on it.

2. Borrowed authority works because the writer never claims to outrank the profession. If the writer simply asserted that walkability matters more than unit count, an architect could reasonably disagree with one outsider's taste. But the Charter, the code of ethics, and the 8-80 principle are the profession's own published commitments, so refusing them would be self-contradiction, not a difference of opinion. The leverage comes from memory rather than argument: the writer is the one who remembers what the addressee already promised. This also keeps the tone deferential, which the open-letter form needs, while making the moral pressure harder to shrug off than any claim the writer could make on personal authority.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The letter argues that adding housing units and preserving human-scale, livable streets are not opposing goals but obligations a profession can meet at once. Drawing on your own observation, reading, and experience, write an essay that argues the extent to which you agree or disagree with the claim that communities can pursue density and livability together without sacrificing one for the other. Develop your position with specific, relevant evidence, and consider a perspective different from your own.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Treating the first paragraph's acknowledgment of the housing shortage as the writer's actual thesis. The crisis is conceded ground, not the claim; the argument is that density and human scale can be honored together, and the concession exists to make that turn land fairly.
- Reading the marked concession in paragraph three as the writer letting architects off the hook. A concession grants the opposing side real force, but here it is immediately followed by a turn back to the profession's own research; students should see that conceding is a setup for advancing, not a surrender of the position.
- Mislabeling the anaphora in paragraph two as ordinary repetition or parallelism. The device is the repeated "when" frame at the START of successive clauses building to a delayed main clause; students often tag the whole long sentence as parallelism without noticing the initial-position repetition that defines anaphora.
- Assuming an open letter must attack its addressee to have force. This letter never says the architects are wrong; its whole engine is holding them to principles they already endorsed, which is a different and often stronger move than accusation.

AP exam alignment:

"This opener teaches how an argument earns standing through genuine concession and borrowed authority: the writer grants the opposing reality its full weight, then holds the addressee to their own stated commitments rather than to an outside standard. It models the rhetorical situation of an open letter (a named, more powerful audience with the public overhearing) and lets students analyze how anaphora, antithesis, and a delayed periodic structure carry deference while still pressing a charge."